

To maintain worker safety, corporations and even small, privately held companies must adhere to standards set by the Occupational Safety & Health Administration (OSHA). OSHA regulations require a workplace that keeps workers safe from everything from slips and falls to major industrial hazards like exposure to toxic chemicals. OSHA has the power to halt production at job sites deemed unsafe.

Food production and processing are further subject to health and safety standards set by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) and the US Department of Agriculture's Food Safety and Inspection Service.

Liabilities, warranties, and guarantees

Companies that sell goods and services in the United States must adhere to various consumer protection laws that are generally promulgated and enforced at the state level. For example, New York State maintains a Division of Consumer Protection, California has its Department of Consumer Affairs, and the Texas Attorney General maintains a Consumer Protection unit. These organizations enforce laws concerning the terms and conditions under which goods and services are sold to the public. New York State, for instance, requires stores to post their refund policies in open view, maintain transparent rebate policies, and limit restrictive provisions on gift card redemption.

Intellectual property law and patent protection

Intellectual property laws in the US are upheld and enforced mainly through the United States Patent and Trademark Office (USPTO) and the US Copyright Office.

The USPTO adjudicates the validity of patent claims and awards patents on new designs of products, services, and business methods. The USPTO also evaluates trademark claims.

The Copyright Office registers claims and issues certificates for copyrights on literary, artistic, and design works, such as a corporate logo.

ORGANIZATIONS AND RESOURCES

Compliance and corporate responsibility

The Securities and Exchange Commission enforces Sarbanes-Oxley compliance.
<http://www.sec.gov>

Standards and quality control

ISO's site provides full information on all of the standards overseen by the organization.
<http://www.iso.org>

Health, safety, and the environment

OSHA's website offers information on new regulations, compliance tips, and enforcement actions.
<https://www.osha.gov>

The EPA has online tools for checking compliance with federal environmental regulations.
<http://www.epa.gov>

Information on food safety laws and practices can be obtained from the FDA's site.
<http://www.fda.gov>

Liability, warranties, and guarantees

In the US, consumer protection generally falls to the state level. Individual state websites provide information on regulations concerning public sale of goods and services.

Intellectual property law

The USPTO is the main resource for all information concerning the filing of patent applications.
<http://www.uspto.gov>

The US Copyright Office website includes information about the copyright process and fees.
<http://copyright.gov>

In Canada

Information on corporate law and operations in Canada can be obtained from the federal government's Competition Bureau.
<http://www.competitionbureau.gc.ca>
<http://www.bureaudelaconurrence.gc.ca>